INDIA- TRANSPORT GEOGRAPHY

HIGHWAYS • RAILWAYS • AIRWAYS • WATERWAYS

Complete, updated notes for UPSC CSE and State PSCs

Conceptual • Data-rich • Map-oriented • Prelims + Mains

AT A GLANCE: LATEST VERIFIED SNAPSHOT

Mode / indicator	Latest figure used	Date / interpretation
Total road network	63.73 lakh km	Reported March 2026; India has the world's second-largest road network.
National Highways	1,46,572 km	March 2026 official summary; older official series gives 1,46,204 km at March 2025.
Railway route length	69,439 route km	As of March 2025; Economic Survey 2025–26 statistical series.
Broad-gauge electrification	99.6%	Reported July 2026; electrification figure refers to broad-gauge network.
Operational airports	165	July 2026 government fact sheet; airport counts can vary by definition.
National Waterways	111 notified; 32 operational	111 NWs span 20,187 km; operational network reported as 5,155 km in March 2026.
Inland-waterway cargo	218 million tonnes	FY 2025–26, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways; check whether final/provisional in later updates.
Major-port cargo handling capacity	1,728 MMTPA	Reported 2026; MMTPA = million metric tonnes per annum.

PART I — ROADS AND NATIONAL HIGHWAYS

1. Concept and geographical significance

Road transport is the most flexible mode for door-to-door movement and first-/last-mile connectivity. It is especially important for short and medium distances, rural access, perishable goods, tourism, defence logistics and linking farms, factories, markets, railway stations, airports and ports.

- Physical geography: roads can cross rugged terrain through tunnels, bridges, passes and cuttings, but steep gradients, landslides, floods, snow and erosion raise construction and maintenance costs.
- Economic geography: industrial clusters, ports, mining belts, agricultural markets and large cities generate traffic and justify higher-capacity corridors.
- Social geography: all-weather rural roads improve access to schools, health care, markets and administrative services.
- Strategic geography: border roads support troop movement, supply chains and access to remote frontier areas.

2. Road-network hierarchy

Category	Primary role	Governance / exam distinction
Expressways / access-controlled high-speed corridors	High-speed inter-city movement; controlled entry/exit	Access-controlled roads are not synonymous with every National Highway.
National Highways (NH)	Connect national/state capitals, major cities, ports, industrial areas, borders and strategic locations	Union-level network; MoRTH/NHAI and other agencies have different responsibilities.
State Highways (SH)	Connect state capitals, district headquarters and important towns to NHs and each other	Primarily a state responsibility.
Major District Roads (MDR)	Connect production areas and district-level centres to higher-order roads	Important for regional and market connectivity.
Other District Roads (ODR) and Village Roads	Local access and rural connectivity	Crucial for last-mile access; often state/local bodies and rural-road

		programmes.

3. Key road statistics and trends

Indicator	Figure	Date / note
Total road network	63.73 lakh km	March 2026 official fact sheet.
National Highways	1,46,572 km	March 2026; grew from 91,287 km in FY 2013–14.
4-lane-and-above NHs	45,516 km	March 2026 government summary; definitions may differ across series.
Road length under Bharatmala completed	22,590 km	As of 31 March 2026.
Roads built under PMGSY, 2014–2026	4.11 lakh km	Government-reported series; distinguish programme achievements from total road network.

Source note: Official government summaries may use different reference dates and classifications. For a test or answer, state the date attached to the figure rather than treating every number found online as contradictory.

4. Major corridors and projects

Project / corridor	Geographical purpose and exam relevance
Golden Quadrilateral	Links Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata; connects major metropolitan, industrial and market centres.
North–South Corridor	Broadly links Srinagar with Kanyakumari; improves longitudinal connectivity.
East–West Corridor	Broadly links Silchar with Porbandar; strengthens east–west integration.
Bharatmala Pariyojana	Economic corridors, inter-corridor and feeder roads, national-corridor efficiency, border/international links, coastal/port connectivity and expressways.

Delhi–Mumbai Expressway	High-capacity north-west to west-coast link; logistics, industrial and freight connectivity.
Mumbai–Pune Expressway	Important early access-controlled expressway linking a major port-metropolitan region with an industrial/education hub.
Atal Tunnel / Himalayan road tunnels	All-weather connectivity through difficult mountain terrain; strategic and tourism value, alongside ecological risks.
Border Roads Organisation (BRO) roads	Strategic roads in high-altitude, border and remote areas; terrain, weather and security make construction costly.

5. Policy instruments

- Bharatmala Pariyojana: corridor-based highway development, port and border connectivity, feeder roads and freight efficiency.
- PMGSY: rural road connectivity; PMGSY-IV aims to connect 25,000 unconnected habitations by 2029, according to the 2026 government summary.
- PM GatiShakti: GIS-based integrated infrastructure planning across ministries and states/UTs; aims to reduce silo-based planning.
- FASTag and electronic toll collection: reduce stopping and improve tolling efficiency; barrier-free tolling initiatives use electronic systems.
- National Logistics Policy: promotes integrated logistics, digitalisation, standardisation and lower logistics costs.

6. Why roads are unevenly distributed

- Dense population, high urbanisation, industry and intensive agriculture support dense road networks in the Indo-Gangetic Plain, coastal belts and major metropolitan regions.
- The Himalayas, north-eastern hills, deserts, forests, floodplains and sparsely populated areas raise unit construction costs or require specialised engineering.
- Road density is not simply a measure of development: area, terrain, population density and the type of road counted affect comparisons.

7. Road transport: strengths and limitations

Strengths	Limitations / externalities
Door-to-door flexibility; high route flexibility	Congestion, crashes and high emissions per tonne-km relative to efficient rail/water freight.
Good for short-distance, time-sensitive and perishable cargo	Fuel-price exposure; maintenance costs and road wear.
Supports remote and rural access	Land acquisition, habitat fragmentation, noise and urban sprawl.
Useful for defence and disaster response	Landslides, floods, heat damage and extreme-weather disruption.

PRELIMS TRAPS — ROADS National Highways are only a part of India's total road network. A high-speed corridor is not automatically the same as a conventional NH. Bharatmala is not the rural-road programme; PMGSY is strongly associated with rural road connectivity.

PART II — RAILWAYS

8. Why railways matter in India

Railways are suited to high-volume passenger movement and bulk freight over medium and long distances. Their importance is particularly high for coal, iron ore, cement, fertilisers, foodgrains, containers and long-distance passenger travel.

- Geographical advantage: level plains and broad valleys reduce gradients and engineering costs; mountains require tunnels, bridges, loops and costly alignments.
- Economic role: connect mineral belts, power plants, steel centres, agricultural hinterlands, ports and consumption markets.
- Energy/climate: electric rail can reduce direct diesel use and emissions, especially when electricity generation becomes cleaner.
- Network effect: the value of a railway line rises when it connects to terminals, industrial sidings, ports, logistics parks and other rail corridors.

9. Current network facts

Indicator	Latest verified figure	Date / scope

Railway route length	69,439 route km	March 2025; Economic Survey 2025–26.
Electrified route kilometres	69.4 thousand km	November 2025 provisional Statistical Appendix; later official updates report 99.6% broad-gauge electrification in July 2026.
Broad-gauge network electrified	99.6%	July 2026; this is not the same as saying every route, yard, siding or metre of track is electrified.
Freight loading	About 1,614.9 million tonnes	FY 2024–25, revenue-earning originating traffic in Economic Survey statistical series.
Vande Bharat services	162 trainsets/services cited	July 2026 government fact sheet; confirm exact counting convention if a later exam asks for a live number.

10. Major railway corridors and projects

Project / route	Why it matters
Eastern Dedicated Freight Corridor (EDFC)	Primarily links the eastern coal/mineral and industrial hinterland with northern markets; improves freight separation from passenger services.
Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC)	Links the Delhi-NCR/hinterland with the Jawaharlal Nehru Port region; container and port-linked freight.
Mumbai–Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail	India’s first high-speed rail project; route about 508 km, design speed 350 km/h, as reported in July 2026 government material.
Economic Railway Corridors	Focus on energy, mineral and cement routes; port connectivity; and high-traffic-density routes.

Kashmir rail connectivity / Chenab Bridge	Engineering through Himalayan terrain; the Chenab rail bridge is a landmark arch bridge.
Konkan Railway	Coastal and Western Ghats terrain; tunnels, bridges, heavy monsoon and landslide risks are central geographical themes.
Northeast rail connectivity	Links remote states and markets; difficult relief, heavy rainfall, fragile slopes and border geography shape costs and alignments.

11. Railways and physical geography

- Northern plains: relatively favourable gradients and dense population/markets, but rivers, floods and shifting channels complicate bridges and embankments.
- Peninsular plateau: mineral belts and industrial centres create freight demand; hard rock and dissected relief influence alignments.
- Western Ghats and Konkan: short distance between coast and plateau can still require many tunnels and bridges because of steep relief and intense rainfall.
- Himalayas and Northeast: seismicity, landslides, unstable slopes, rivers and high rainfall demand resilient engineering and maintenance.
- Deserts: sand movement, heat and water scarcity affect construction and upkeep.

12. Rail modernisation and safety

- Electrification: reduces dependence on diesel traction and can lower operating emissions, depending on the electricity mix.
- Kavach: indigenous automatic train-protection system intended to help prevent collisions and improve safety; deployment is route-specific and should not be assumed universal.
- Amrit Bharat Station Scheme: station redevelopment and passenger amenities.
- Vande Bharat and Amrit Bharat services: different service/product categories; do not treat their names as interchangeable.

- Hydrogen fuel-cell trainset: government reported a 10-coach indigenous trainset on the Jind–Sonipat section in July 2026; distinguish launch/operation reports from network-wide deployment.
- Track doubling/multi-tracking, signalling, bridges, rolling stock and terminal capacity are all important; electrification alone does not remove bottlenecks.

13. Railways: strengths and challenges

Strengths	Challenges
High capacity and energy efficiency for bulk freight	Congested mixed-use tracks where passenger and freight trains share capacity.
Lower emissions per tonne-km than road in many operating conditions	Last-mile access, terminal handling and freight scheduling can limit competitiveness.
Connects interior resource regions to ports and markets	Land acquisition, project delays, cost overruns and difficult terrain.
Potential for cleaner mobility with electrification	Safety, maintenance, affordability and accessibility require continuing investment.

PRELIMS TRAPS — RAILWAYS Route kilometres measure the length of the route network; track kilometres count individual tracks and can be greater where lines are doubled or multi-tracked. ‘99.6% electrified’ refers to the broad-gauge network in the cited 2026 source, not necessarily every siding or railway facility.

PART III — AIRWAYS

14. Role and geographical logic

Air transport is the fastest mode for long-distance passenger travel and high-value, low-weight, urgent or perishable cargo. Airport location depends on population and income, business travel, tourism, terrain, weather, military/security constraints, land availability and the catchment area served.

- Airways are especially important for remote islands, mountain states, the Northeast, medical evacuation, disaster response and time-sensitive trade.
- Air cargo is valuable for pharmaceuticals, electronics, gems and jewellery, express parcels, seafood, flowers and other high-value or perishable products.

- Airport connectivity can stimulate tourism and services, but benefits depend on frequency, affordability, ground transport and actual demand.

15. Current aviation facts

Indicator	Latest verified figure	Date / note
Operational airports	165	July 2026 official fact sheet; counts may vary by definition and operational status.
Airports operationalised under UDAN	95 airports, heliports and water aerodromes connected through 679 routes	As of 15 July 2026; not all are conventional airports.
Passengers flown under UDAN	More than 1.68 crore	As of 15 July 2026.
Greenfield airports approved after 2014	25	Reported July 2026; approved does not necessarily mean operational.
Digi Yatra	Active at 38 airports	Government-reported July 2026; digital identity/boarding facilitation, not an airport expansion programme.
Domestic aviation market	India described as the world’s third-largest domestic aviation market	Economic Survey 2025–26 summary; market rankings depend on metric and period.

16. Major airport regions and patterns

Region / airport cluster	Geographical and economic role
Delhi-NCR	National capital, government, business, tourism and major domestic/international hub.
Mumbai	Financial centre, dense urban market and major international gateway; constrained land and urban airspace.
Bengaluru–Hyderabad–Chennai	Technology, services, manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, automotive and

	business travel.
Kolkata–Guwahati	Eastern India gateway and Northeast connectivity; riverine/deltaic and regional access issues.
Kochi–Thiruvananthapuram–Calicut/Kozhikode	Coastal Kerala, tourism, migration-linked travel and international connections.
Amritsar–Jaipur–Lucknow–Ahmedabad	Regional business, tourism, diaspora and administrative demand.
Port Blair and island airfields	Strategic, tourism, emergency and essential-service links for island territories.
Leh and Himalayan airports	Strategic and remote-area access; high altitude, weather and terrain constrain operations.

17. Major aviation initiatives

- UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik): regional connectivity scheme aimed at making air travel more accessible and connecting underserved/unserved locations.
- Greenfield Airport Policy: framework for developing new airports; approval, construction and commercial operation are separate stages.
- Digi Yatra: paperless, facial-recognition-enabled passenger processing at participating airports; users should consider consent and data-protection issues.
- Airport modernisation: terminals, runways, navigation, security, cargo facilities and public transport links.
- Modified UDAN: approved in March 2026 for FY 2026–27 to FY 2035–36 with ₹28,840 crore outlay; official summary envisages 100 new airports and 200 modern helipads.

18. Aviation: constraints and environmental issues

- High operating and infrastructure costs; airport viability depends on traffic and airline economics.
- Weather disruption from fog, thunderstorms, cyclones, crosswinds and mountain conditions.
- Noise, land take, urban sprawl, local air pollution and aviation greenhouse-gas emissions.

- Airport access is not just runway infrastructure: rail/metro, buses, roads, parking and logistics connections matter.
- Regional routes can require carefully designed support, viable schedules and sustained demand.

PRELIMS TRAPS — AIRWAYS UDAN route counts, airports connected, airports operationalised and greenfield airports approved are different indicators. Do not interpret ‘approved’ as ‘open’. Digi Yatra is a passenger-processing initiative, not an airport construction scheme.

PART IV — WATERWAYS, PORTS AND SHIPPING

19. Two distinct systems

System	What it includes	Main function
Inland Water Transport (IWT)	Navigable rivers, canals, backwaters, creeks and notified National Waterways	Bulk cargo, passenger/ferry services, tourism and links between inland terminals and ports.
Maritime / coastal transport	Sea routes, coastal shipping, ports, terminals and vessels	Domestic coastal movement and international trade.

Water transport can be fuel-efficient and cost-effective for heavy, bulky cargo, but performance depends on navigable depth, channel width, seasonal flow, dredging, terminal access, bridges, locks, navigational aids and reliable last-mile links.

20. National Waterways: current facts

Indicator	Latest verified figure	Date / scope
National Waterways notified	111	Under the National Waterways Act, 2016.
Combined length of notified NWs	20,187 km	Spread across 23 States and 4 Union Territories.
Operational National Waterways	32	As of March 2026; operational status requires suitable fairway, terminals and navigation aids.
Length of operational	5,155 km	As of March 2026.

waterways		
IWT cargo movement	145.84 million tonnes	FY 2024–25, PIB release dated 27 April 2026.
IWT cargo movement	218 million tonnes	FY 2025–26, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways page; verify if later final series revises this figure.
National Waterway 1	Ganga–Bhagirathi–Hooghly system, Haldia–Prayagraj/Allahabad reach	Core Ganga waterway corridor; often discussed with Jal Marg Vikas Project.
National Waterway 2	Brahmaputra, Dhubri–Sadiya	Northeast inland navigation corridor.
National Waterway 3	West Coast Canal, Kerala	Backwater/canal network; important for passenger and freight connectivity.
National Waterway 4	Krishna–Godavari river system and linked canals	Important for Andhra Pradesh and east-coast hinterland connectivity.
National Waterway 5	East Coast Canal and linked river systems in Odisha region	Connects parts of the east-coast canal/river system; project status is segment-specific.

21. Important National Waterways for map work

NW	River / route	States / geographical significance
NW-1	Ganga–Bhagirathi–Hooghly system	Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal; connects hinterland with Haldia/Kolkata region.
NW-2	Brahmaputra, Dhubri–Sadiya	Assam; regional freight and passenger transport, difficult seasonal hydrology and braided channels.
NW-3	West Coast Canal	Kerala; backwaters and canals, coastal

		settlements and regional movement.
NW-4	Krishna–Godavari river systems and connected canals	Andhra Pradesh and linked regions; inland/coastal multimodal potential.
NW-5	East Coast Canal and linked Brahmani–Kharsua–Dhamra / deltaic systems	Odisha region; industrial and port connectivity potential.
NW-16	Barak River	Assam and Northeast connectivity.
NW-68 / NW-111	Mandovi / Zuari rivers	Goa; river navigation, port/industrial activity and tourism.

22. Major ports and port geography

Ports are interfaces between sea transport and the hinterland. Port performance depends on natural harbour conditions, draft, coastline, tidal range, hinterland industries, rail/road access, container terminals, customs and logistics efficiency.

Coast / region	Major ports to locate	Geographical / economic context
West coast — Gujarat	Deendayal (Kandla), major non-major ports such as Mundra and Pipavav	Gulf of Kachchh/Khambhat, energy, containers, petrochemicals and industrial hinterland.
West coast — Maharashtra	Mumbai, Jawaharlal Nehru Port (JNPA/Nhava Sheva)	Large urban-industrial hinterland; container trade; congestion and land constraints.
West coast — Goa / Karnataka	Mormugao, New Mangalore	Iron ore historically important at Mormugao; New Mangalore supports regional industry and energy cargo.
West coast — Kerala	Cochin (Kochi)	Natural harbour/lagoon setting, transshipment potential, petroleum and

		regional trade.
East coast — Tamil Nadu	Chennai, Kamarajar (Ennore), V.O. Chidambaranar (Thoothukudi)	Automobiles, manufacturing, containers, energy and southern hinterland.
East coast — Andhra Pradesh	Visakhapatnam	Natural harbour, steel/industry, bulk cargo and naval significance.
East coast — Odisha	Paradip	Bulk cargo, minerals, coal and industrial hinterland.
East coast — West Bengal	Kolkata–Haldia	Hooghly riverine port system; tidal navigation, siltation/dredging and Ganga hinterland links.

23. Major-port data and policy

Indicator / initiative	Latest verified fact	Why it matters
Major-port cargo-handling capacity	1,728 MMTPA	Reported in 2026; capacity is not the same as actual cargo handled.
Major-port cargo handled	915.17 million tonnes	FY 2025–26 official summary.
Average vessel turnaround time	48.8 hours	Reported for FY 2025–26; shorter turnaround improves port efficiency.
Sagarmala	Port-led development, port modernisation, coastal shipping, port connectivity and industrial/logistics integration	Links port capacity to economic clusters and hinterland transport.
Maritime India Vision 2030 / Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047	Long-term maritime capacity, logistics and competitiveness frameworks	Useful for policy answers on ports, shipping and blue economy.
Jal Marg Vikas Project	Development of NW-1; terminals at Varanasi, Sahibganj and Haldia among key facilities	Aims to improve navigability and multimodal freight on the Ganga system.

24. Why inland waterways are underused in some regions

- Seasonal variation in river discharge and water depth, especially in monsoon-dependent rivers.
- Siltation, shifting channels, meanders, sandbars and braided river morphology.
- Insufficient terminals, cargo aggregation, storage, navigational aids and dependable schedules.
- Bridges with limited vertical clearance and conflicts with other water uses.
- Ecological constraints: dredging, bank erosion, aquatic habitats, wetlands, fish migration and local livelihoods.
- Multimodal challenge: a waterway becomes commercially useful when it connects efficiently with road, rail, warehouses and industrial/port nodes.

PRELIMS TRAPS — WATERWAYS 111 National Waterways are notified, not all operational. ‘20,187 km’ refers to the combined length of notified waterways; ‘5,155 km’ is the reported operational length. Major-port capacity (MMTPA) is not the same as actual cargo handled (MT).

PART V — INTEGRATED / MULTIMODAL TRANSPORT

25. How the modes complement one another

Supply-chain task	Often suitable mode / combination	Reason
Farm to local mandi / factory gate	Road	Flexible collection and last-mile delivery.
Coal / iron ore / cement over long distances	Rail; inland waterway where feasible	High-volume bulk movement.
Containers between hinterland and port	Rail + road + port terminal	Rail for trunk haul; road for first/last mile; port for maritime leg.
Urgent, high-value, light cargo	Air + road	Speed and controlled distribution.
Remote island / isolated region	Air + sea / ferry + local roads	Geography may leave few alternatives.
Large, bulky cargo near navigable river	Inland waterway + road/rail	Can reduce unit freight cost if terminals and navigation are reliable.

26. PM GatiShakti and logistics integration

PM GatiShakti is a GIS-based National Master Plan intended to coordinate infrastructure planning across ministries and states/UTs. Its geographical logic is to plan transport corridors alongside industrial parks, ports, logistics hubs, energy networks and urban infrastructure, reducing missing links and duplicated investment.

- Multimodal logistics parks and terminals help transfer cargo between modes.
- Port connectivity roads and rail links expand the effective hinterland of ports.
- Dedicated freight corridors can release capacity on mixed passenger-freight lines.
- Digital documentation, tracking and standardised processes reduce non-physical logistics delays.
- The lowest-cost mode on the trunk route may not deliver the lowest end-to-end cost if handling, waiting and first/last-mile costs are high.

27. Transport, regional development and environment

Dimension	Potential gains	Risks / policy challenge
Regional development	Market access, jobs, tourism, industrial investment, access to services	Benefits may concentrate around major hubs and bypass peripheral areas.
Agriculture	Lower spoilage, access to input and output markets, cold-chain logistics	Road expansion without storage/cold chains may not solve perishability.
Industry and trade	Lower transit times, more reliable supply chains, port competitiveness	Land acquisition, displacement, fragmented habitats and induced land-use change.
Climate and energy	Electrified rail and efficient water freight can reduce emissions per tonne-km	Road/air growth can raise emissions; electricity source and utilisation matter.
Disaster resilience	Multiple routes and modes support evacuation and relief	Floods, cyclones, landslides, heat and sea-level rise can disrupt transport assets.

Equity	Rural and regional access, mobility for underserved groups	Affordability, accessibility and reliable services determine whether connectivity is inclusive.

28. Telangana and Andhra Pradesh: regional linkage box

- Telangana is a landlocked state: road and rail corridors connect Hyderabad and inland industrial/agricultural centres to ports outside the state, especially on the Andhra Pradesh coast.
- Hyderabad’s airport, IT/services economy, pharmaceuticals and high-value manufacturing generate passenger and air-cargo demand; road access and logistics facilities are part of the wider airport system.
- Railway and highway corridors connect Telangana’s mineral, cement, power, agricultural and manufacturing nodes to markets across central and southern India.
- Andhra Pradesh’s long coastline and ports create opportunities for port-led industrial development, export logistics, fisheries and coastal shipping.
- The Krishna–Godavari systems and notified NW-4 offer inland-waterway potential, but actual use depends on operational stretches, navigability, terminal infrastructure and multimodal connections.
- Map practice: Hyderabad, Secunderabad, Warangal, Ramagundam, Vijayawada, Visakhapatnam, Kakinada, Krishnapatnam and major road/rail links to coastal gateways.

PART VI — MAP CHECKLIST

1. Golden Quadrilateral: Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata and connecting highway legs.
2. North–South and East–West highway corridors.
3. Major expressways and high-speed corridor examples; locate the states they traverse.
4. Eastern and Western Dedicated Freight Corridors; their hinterland and port connections.
5. Mumbai–Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alignment and major bridge/tunnel examples.
6. Major airport clusters: Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Kolkata, Kochi, Guwahati, Leh and Port Blair.

7. Major ports on both coasts and their industrial hinterlands.
8. NW-1 Ganga system, NW-2 Brahmaputra, NW-3 Kerala West Coast Canal, NW-4 Krishna–Godavari system, NW-5 Odisha-linked river/canal system.
9. Terrain constraints: Himalayas, Western Ghats, Thar Desert, Brahmaputra valley, Ganga plain and major deltas.
10. Multimodal nodes: ports, freight corridors, industrial clusters, airports and logistics parks.

PART VII — RAPID REVISION TABLE

Question prompt	Correct distinction / answer cue
India’s road-network rank?	Second-largest road network in the world, according to official 2026 summary.
NH network in March 2026?	1,46,572 km in the cited government fact sheet.
Railway route length in March 2025?	69,439 route km.
Broad-gauge electrification in July 2026?	99.6%, as reported by the government.
Operational airports in July 2026?	165, according to the government fact sheet.
National Waterways notified?	111.
National Waterways operational in March 2026?	32, over 5,155 km reported operational length.
NW-1?	Ganga–Bhagirathi–Hooghly system.
NW-2?	Brahmaputra, Dhubri–Sadiya.
NW-3?	West Coast Canal in Kerala.
NW-4?	Krishna–Godavari river system and linked canals.
Road rural-connectivity programme?	Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY).
Port-led development programme?	Sagarmala.
Integrated GIS-based infrastructure planning?	PM GatiShakti.
Automatic train protection system?	Kavach; do not assume universal coverage.
Regional air-connectivity scheme?	UDAN.
Passenger processing initiative?	Digi Yatra.
Major-port capacity unit?	MMTPA = million metric tonnes per annum; capacity is not actual

	throughput.

PART VIII — PRELIMS TRAPS AND COMMON ERRORS

- Do not mix figures from different years without showing their dates.
- Do not confuse route km with track km in railway data.
- Do not confuse National Highways with India's total road network.
- Do not assume every National Waterway is operational.
- Do not confuse an airport approved under a scheme with an airport that is operational.
- Do not equate port capacity with cargo handled; one is a capacity measure, the other is actual throughput over a period.
- Do not assume that a road or rail project automatically lowers logistics costs; terminal access, congestion, reliability and handling also matter.
- Do not state that rail electrification automatically means zero emissions; emissions depend partly on the electricity mix.
- Do not describe water transport as universally cheap: navigability, seasonality, terminals and last-mile costs determine commercial viability.
- Do not treat UDAN, Digi Yatra, Bharatmala, PMGSY, Sagarmala and PM GatiShakti as interchangeable schemes.

PART IX — MAINS ANSWER FRAMEWORKS

29. 'Transport infrastructure is a driver of regional development, but its benefits are uneven.' Discuss.

Suggested structure:

11. Introduction: define transport infrastructure as a network that reduces spatial friction and connects people, resources, production and markets.
12. Mechanisms: lower travel time and freight cost; access to jobs and services; market integration; agglomeration economies; tourism and investment.
13. Geographical variation: plains and dense economic regions tend to support denser networks; mountains, islands, deserts and remote border regions face higher costs.
14. Uneven benefits: hubs may gain disproportionately; bypassed districts, low-income households and small producers may remain disconnected.

15. Policy response: multimodal planning, rural last-mile roads, affordable services, climate-resilient infrastructure, transparent land acquisition and environmental safeguards.
16. Conclusion: evaluate connectivity by reliability, affordability, accessibility and resilience—not network length alone.

30. ‘Explain the case for multimodal logistics in India.’

17. Explain comparative advantage of road, rail, air and water transport.
18. Describe how first/last-mile road links feed railways, ports and airports.
19. Discuss PM GatiShakti, dedicated freight corridors, logistics parks and port connectivity.
20. Explain gains: lower end-to-end cost, predictable delivery, reduced congestion and potentially lower emissions.
21. Discuss barriers: fragmented planning, terminal gaps, uneven waterway navigability, land acquisition, digital integration and institutional coordination.
22. Conclude with outcome-based metrics: total logistics cost, transit reliability, modal share, emissions and service reach.

PART X — SOURCES AND DATA NOTES

Official data are periodically revised; use the reporting date stated beside each figure. Some figures are provisional or come from different official releases with different scopes.

23.1. Press Information Bureau — India’s Infrastructure Transformation: From Connectivity to Capacity (12 August 2026). Roads, railways, airports, ports and waterways.
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24.2. Press Information Bureau — A Ride through the Inland Waterways of India (27 April 2026). National Waterways, operational stretches, NW-1 to NW-5, cargo.
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25.3. **Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways — Inland Water Transport.**
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Guruji Says

GEOGRAPHY FIRST - Transport is not merely a list of roads, railways, airports and ports. It is a spatial system shaped by relief, rivers, climate, population, industry, trade and public policy. The strongest UPSC answers explain why a network is located where it is, whom it connects, what it moves, and what social and environmental trade-offs it creates.-Jaiprakash Rau